

Collaborative  
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# Collaborative Writing

IB 514: Scientific Writing

# Dissertation Manuscripts as Collaborative Efforts

## Collaborative Writing

### Guiding Principles

### Tools and Conventions

### Collaboration is Communication

### Navigating Disagreements

### Task Management

### Authorship Conversations

### Hierarchy and Power Imbalance

### Final Thoughts

- **You own the draft.** As first author, you are responsible for maintaining *momentum* on the manuscript and for ensuring its *integrity*.
- **Advisors may be co-authors, don't expect them to be editors.** They may choose to revise and redirect, but the *intellectual initiative* should come from you.
- **Co-authorship is not automatic.** Contribution, not relationship or seniority, should determine authorship; clarify expectations *before* writing begins.
- **Co-authors have competing priorities.** You, your advisor, and your collaborators need not share the same *incentives*.

# Tools for Collaborative Writing

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## Choose tools that match your collaboration needs

**MS Word / Apple Pages** Share via email or cloud storage. Well-known; track changes; offline editing; weak for complex or equation-heavy formatting.

**Google Docs** Real-time cloud-based editing. Low barrier to entry; suggesting mode; comment threads; best for early drafts or non- $\text{\LaTeX}$  collaborators.

**Overleaf** Cloud-based  $\text{\LaTeX}$  editor with real-time collaboration. Comment threads; full revision history; Git sync; the standard for  $\text{\LaTeX}$  manuscripts with multiple authors.

**Git / GitHub** Version-controlled repositories; cloud-based. Full audit trail; branching; ideal for  $\text{\LaTeX}$  and code; not real-time; steeper learning curve.

**Practical Rule:** Agree on a tool *before* writing begins. Mid-project migrations are time-consuming and introduce errors.

# File Versioning

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If you're not using version control software (Git)...

**File Naming** Ambiguous filenames are a form of technical debt. Adopt a convention and enforce it from day one.

*Avoid*     `draft_final_v2_JSmith_revised_FINAL.doc`

*Better*    `2025-11-14_manuscript.doc`

*Better*    `manuscript_v07.doc`

## Versioning Conventions

- Use **ISO dates** (YYYY-MM-DD) or **sequential version numbers** (v01, v02) — not both. Append commenting author initials.
- **Tag submission-ready versions** explicitly (v\_submitted, v\_R1)
- **Don't delete old versions** — archive them in an /archive subfolder

## Comment and Annotation Discipline

- Resolve or explicitly defer all comments before circulating a new draft
- Use GitHub Issues or margin note comment threads to track unresolved questions and decisions
- Do not leave unresolved comments at submission — some journal portals expose tracked changes to reviewers

# Establishing Norms and Expectations

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## Collaboration is Communication

Most conflicts stem from unmet unstated expectations

### Clarify at the start:

- **Authorship:** Confirm whether your advisor will be last author and who is to be offered (the right to decline) authorship.
- **Level of involvement:** Will advisor/collaborators co-write sections, provide key figures, or provide feedback on drafts?
- **Escalation path:** Who has final say on journal choice, framing, interpretation, etc.? What happens if co-authors disagree?
- **Primary channel:** email, Slack, GitHub Issues — consider one platform for decisions, one for quick questions.
- **Response expectations:** what is a reasonable turnaround for draft review (1 week? 3 weeks?) and for quick questions (48 hours?).
- **Meeting cadence:** regular check-ins vs. milestone-driven meetings — both have costs and benefits.

**Decision documentation:** For large collaborations; all substantive decisions recorded in a shared log (email thread, shared doc, etc.)

# Common Issues

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## Common Friction Points

*Advisor rewrites your draft:* Treat as mentorship; study the changes; ask for rationale on substantive edits.

*Co-author delays for weeks:* Set a gentle deadline when providing updated draft — “*Could you get it back to me by X.*”

*Co-authors disagree:* Raise the conflict openly; do not triangulate between them; request a joint discussion.

## A Common Failure Mode

Decisions made verbally in hallway conversations or lab meetings that are not recorded. Three months later, co-authors remember different outcomes.

# Resolving Disagreements

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## Identify the Type of Disagreement First

| Type                 | Example                                                                                 | Possible Resolution Pathways                                                  |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Scientific</b>    | Disagreement over statistical model choice or interpretation of results                 | Resolve with evidence; consider additional analyses; consult a neutral expert |
| <b>Framing</b>       | Disagreement over how to position paper's contribution                                  | Consult target journal scope; summarize framing of comparable studies         |
| <b>Stylistic</b>     | Disagreement over sentence-level writing choices                                        | Defer to the lead author; style is not worth extended negotiation             |
| <b>Interpersonal</b> | Conflict rooted in prior relationship dynamics, credit concerns, or workload resentment | Address directly and early; do not let it contaminate scientific decisions    |

- Separate *positions* (what someone wants) from *interests* (why they want it) — interests are usually reconcilable
- Put manuscript's quality and reader's needs at the center of dispute
- Seek advice from neutral party (e.g., committee member) if direct resolution is failing

# Dividing and Tracking Contributions

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*Ambiguity about responsibility is a project risk*

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## Task Delegation Principles

- **Assign ownership, not just involvement** — one person is responsible for each deliverable, even if others contribute
- **Be explicit about scope:** “draft the methods section” is a task; “help with methods” is not
- **Revisit assignments** as the project evolves — initial task maps rarely survive contact with data
- **Distinguish writing tasks from research tasks:** the person who ran the analysis may not be the best person to write it up, and vice versa

## Contribution Tracking Tools

**Google Sheets** Simple shared task list with owner, status, and deadline columns — low barrier, universally accessible.

**GitHub Issues** Create tasks with milestone tracking; integrates directly with version-controlled repositories.

**Asana/Trello/Notion** Visual project boards suited to larger or longer-running collaborations.



# The Authorship Conversation

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## When to Have It

**Early** — ideally before data collection begins, certainly before writing starts. Revisit at submission. (Conversations become exponentially harder once significant effort has been invested.)

## What to Establish

- Who will be an author vs. acknowledged contributor?
- What is the expected authorship order and on what basis?
- What happens if contributions change substantially during project?
- Who is the senior and the corresponding author?
- What is the plan if a co-author becomes unresponsive before submission?

## Avoid

- **Gift authorship:** including advisor/collaborator who did not contribute substantially/intellectually
- **Ghost authorship:** omitting those who contributed substantially
- **Retroactive negotiation:** changing authorship order after submission without full co-author agreement

# Hierarchy and Power Imbalance

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## Common Sources of Imbalance

- **Career stage:** harder for student to push back on advisor's framing choices, even when student is domain expert
- **Disciplinary norms:** fields may have incompatible assumptions about authorship order, target journal status, publication timeline
- **Publication pressure:** misaligned incentives around when and where to publish can fracture teams

## Power Differentials Are Structural, Not Personal

Collaborations can involve genuine differences in career vulnerability and publication pressure. Ignoring these dynamics does not neutralize them.

## Protective Strategies

- Document your contributions in writing as work proceeds — do not rely on memory or goodwill at submission time
- Raise authorship expectations explicitly and early, before significant work has been invested
- Consider drafting the *Authorship Contributions* statement early

# Final Thoughts

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*Collaborative writing is a skill that is eased by intentionality.*

## Key Takeaways

- Establish norms explicitly and early
- Communicate openly about expectations and contributions
- Address conflicts directly and with manuscript quality in mind
- Document major decisions and contributions openly